Stories I Ain't Told Nobody Yet
By Jo Carson

VOICE 1: MOTHER

(Pg 93) I am asking you to come back home
before you lose the chance of seein' me alive.
You already missed your daddy.
You missed your uncle Howard.
You missed Luciel.
I kept them and I buried them.
You showed up for the funerals.
Funerals are the easy part.

You even missed that dog you left.
I dug him a hole and put him in it.
It was a Sunday morning, but dead animals
don't wait no better than dead people.

My mama used to say she could feel herself
runnin' short of the breath of life. So can I.
And I am blessed tired of bury in' things I love.
Somebody else can do that job to me.
You'll be back here then; you come for funerals.

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I'd rather you come back now and got my stories.
I've got whole lives of stories that belong to you.
I could fill you up with stories,
stories I ain't told nobody yet,
stories with your name, your blood in them.
Ain't nobody gonna hear them if you don't
and you ain't gonna hear them unless you get back home

When I am dead, it will not matter
how hard you press your ear to the ground.

INTRODUCTION

In the middle of the breathtaking scenic views, rivers, waterfalls, green hills, and quaint historic towns, lies a part of Appalachia overlooked and unseen. Hidden places where people live in conditions that rival any urban slum.

There is a lesson here that possessions, careers and carefully landscaped properties do not bring happiness. It is something that comes from within.

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VOICE 2:

(Pg 29) Mountain people
can't read,
can't write,

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don't wear shoes,
don't have teeth,
don't use soap,
and don't talk plain.
They beat their kids,
beat their friends,
beat their neighbors,
and beat their dogs.
They live on cow peas,
fatback and twenty acres
straight up and down.
They don't have money.
They do have fleas,
overalls,
tobacco patches,
shacks,
shotguns,
foodstamps,
liquor stills,
and at least six junk cars in the front yard.
Right?
Well, let me tell you:
I am from here,

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I'm not like that
and I am damned tired of being told I am.

TRANSITION

Jo Carson sincerely believes that all lives speak truths worth listening to . . . she intentionally sets out to elevate common people, their stories and their language to the level of art, without denying their authenticity. . .

VOICE 3:

(Pg 5) It's gettin' to where
you can't give a person nothin' anymore
and it's too damn bad.
Now, my neighbor
could look the devil in the eye
and say no thanks he didn't want to go to hell,
while at the same time
tryin' to slip Jesus Christ a couple of dollar bills
For the free give of salvation.
He's a hard man
and he's about to drive me crazy.
Fifty cents he puts in my mailbox,
or a dollar or somethin',
and all I did was give his wife
a couple of tomoatoes

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and a mess of old string beans.

And they ain't rich
Then, yesterday, I picked a half a bushel
of them little ol' zucchini squash
and I carried over five or six
and put them on his porch
with a note that said,
"These are a present."
Present was underlined.
and today,
there's a dollar in my mailbox.

The man don't understand
he's doin' a favor
when he takes and eats them damn zucchini,
and when he pays me for 'em,
when he pays me for 'em
it's me ends up beholden to him.

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TRANSITION

According to the most recent U.S. Census, Appalachia has the lowest median household income in the states with a staggering 41.5 per cent of residents falling below the poverty line. But residents take pride in their community's history; and locals are driven to help one another through hard times.

VOICE 4:

(Pg 7) I spent the first years of my life
sittin' on what we called splinter benches
'cause we were too poor for store-bought furniture.
You scooted, you got splinters
My mama used to cry
'cause she wanted a bed with a real mattress
for Grandma Lynn to die on.
Turned out Grandma Lynn didn't need it.
She died mid-sentence at the women's circle
But the first money I ever earned
I got Mama a store-bought mattress.
Daddy bought her two straight-back chairs
so she and him could sit proper at the table.
It was her birthday.
I never seen anybody since
mad so happy by a gift.

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When Daddy finally found regular work
first thing they did was ride down to McEnniss's
and chose a houseful of fancy stuffed furniture.
Bought it on time, had it delivered, and paid for years.
The day it came, Mama and I stood out back
bustin' the old stuff with an ax.
Mama said if they couldn't pay for their bed
she'd rather sleep on the floor than have that one back.
We burnt furniture for kindling all that winter.
Mama'd say, "Here goes the table, Charlie!"
and she and Daddy'd laugh and raise their coffee cups
to toast their new prosperity.

Turns out we burnt what could have been
my fortune in antiques. [I] collects 'em.
-- primitive;
it's the very stuff my mama didn't like,
and now I'm supposed to fix it so it don't ruin clothes
instead of bust it up.
I don't mind, might as well be this as something else,
but if I do get to heaven, if I do get to meet my mama again,
I don't know how in this world or that one
I'm gonna explain why I still go splinters in my seat.

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TRANSITION

"Trailer trash" - Those two words hit me in hard. Throughout my life they've been directed at most everyone I knew and loved. My people had been reduced to two ugly words. I'm here to tell you, it doesn't matter how much money you were raised with, or how you were raised, or what kind of accent you have: a whole lot of people in the world assume that if you are Appalachian, you are the same as that image they have of "trailer trash." They are not trash. They are mothers, fathers, families . . .. They are my people.

VOICE 5:

(Pg 89) I watched the first sunrise
I remember seeing last week.
I am thirty-five.
I'm up at sunrise, I have
a job that ruins my wrists
and two children.
By sunrise, I am already busy.
Once, I sat awake for
a month of sunrises
that began with a call
from the youngest: Mama..,.,
The child got sick
he would not open his eyes.

His room faced west.
I watched—I counted—sunsets.
He is thirteen now
and mows for spending money.
So, Saturday, my husband and I
left the house before dawn.
It was my birthday, my choice,
my present, we went fishing.
I love fishing.
The pain was in my wrists
but casting a fishing line
is not the same as
dis-assembling chickens—
that's their word for it–
on a factory line. My job.
There we sat, me shivering,
In the dark with the crickets
and a rim of bright pink
lit the mountains so quickly
I didn't notice it coming.
It looked like an accident.
What's that? I asked.
This sounds so foolish now.
That light. "The dawn,"

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my husband said and laughed.
I wept, I couldn't stop myself,
I don't ever remember seeing
a sunrise before.
"Happens every morning,
where on earth you been?" he asked.
Cutting up chickens.
Raising children.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier